



GEO in your RFP: evaluation and procurement

When AI visibility is part of a tender, this pack gives you the evaluation criteria to score bidders, the questions that separate real capability from buzzwords, and the contract clauses on data ownership and exit that protect you.

PREPARED FOR [DESTINATION] · WITH THE DIGITAL TOURISM THINK TANK

Most GEO procurement goes wrong in the contract, not the brief. Capability is easy to claim and hard to verify, and the clauses that protect you, data ownership and a clean exit, are the ones most tenders forget to ask for. This pack covers all three: the requirement, the scoring, and the protection.

01 Framing the requirement

State the outcome, not the tactic. A workable requirement statement: we are seeking a supplier to improve how [organisation] is found, understood and recommended by AI assistants and AI search, by bringing our priority content and digital presence up to a defined GEO standard, with the work documented so we can maintain it ourselves. Attach the GEO brief as the standard bidders must meet.

02 Evaluation criteria

Score each bidder against these criteria. The weights are a starting point; adjust them to your priorities, but keep data ownership and transparency weighted heavily.

Criterion	What to look for	Weight
Demonstrated GEO capability	Real examples and results, not restated buzzwords.	20%
Content approach	A clear method for answer-first rewrites that keeps your voice.	15%
Technical and schema	Schema matched to visible content and validated, crawler access handled.	15%
Entity and authority	A plan for consistency across your site and third party platforms.	15%
Measurement and handover	A tracker and documentation you can run after the engagement ends.	15%
Data ownership and transparency	You own the content and structured data, with a clean exit.	20%

03 Questions for bidders

Put these in the RFP and score the answers. They are the vapour test.

- Show two examples where you improved a client's presence in AI answers, and how you measured it.

- How do you prioritise pages, and what is your acceptance test for a rewrite.
- How do you validate schema, and how do you keep it matched to visible content.
- What exactly do we own at the end, and what happens to our data if we leave.
- Which tactics do you refuse to use, and why.

04 Contract clauses that protect you

Build these into the contract. Each protects against a specific, common failure.

01

Data and content ownership

You own all content, structured data and outputs created in the engagement, with full rights to use and amend them. The supplier retains no lock on your material.

02

Exit and portability

On termination, the supplier provides a complete export of your content, schema and data in a usable format, within a defined period, and deletes nothing you have not exported.

03

Maintenance and documentation

The supplier documents the work and hands over what you need to maintain it, so you are not dependent on them to make routine changes.

04

No manipulation

The supplier warrants it will not use hidden text, cloaking, fabricated reviews or any technique against platform guidelines, and is liable for penalties arising from such techniques.

THE TWO THAT MATTER MOST

Data ownership and exit conditions sink more tool and agency decisions than any capability gap. A supplier you cannot leave, or whose work you do not own, is a liability however well they score elsewhere. Weight and contract for these first.

05 Red flags in a bid

-  Capability described only in buzzwords, with no examples or results.
-  No clear acceptance criteria for the work.
-  Vague or absent answers on data ownership and exit.
-  Any tactic that relies on hiding things from visitors or from the platforms.
-  No handover, so you stay dependent on the supplier indefinitely.

Prepared with the Digital Tourism Think Tank as part of the [destination] AI Discoverability programme. This is guidance, not legal advice. Have your own procurement and legal teams adapt the clauses before use.